

COMFORTABLE RIDE

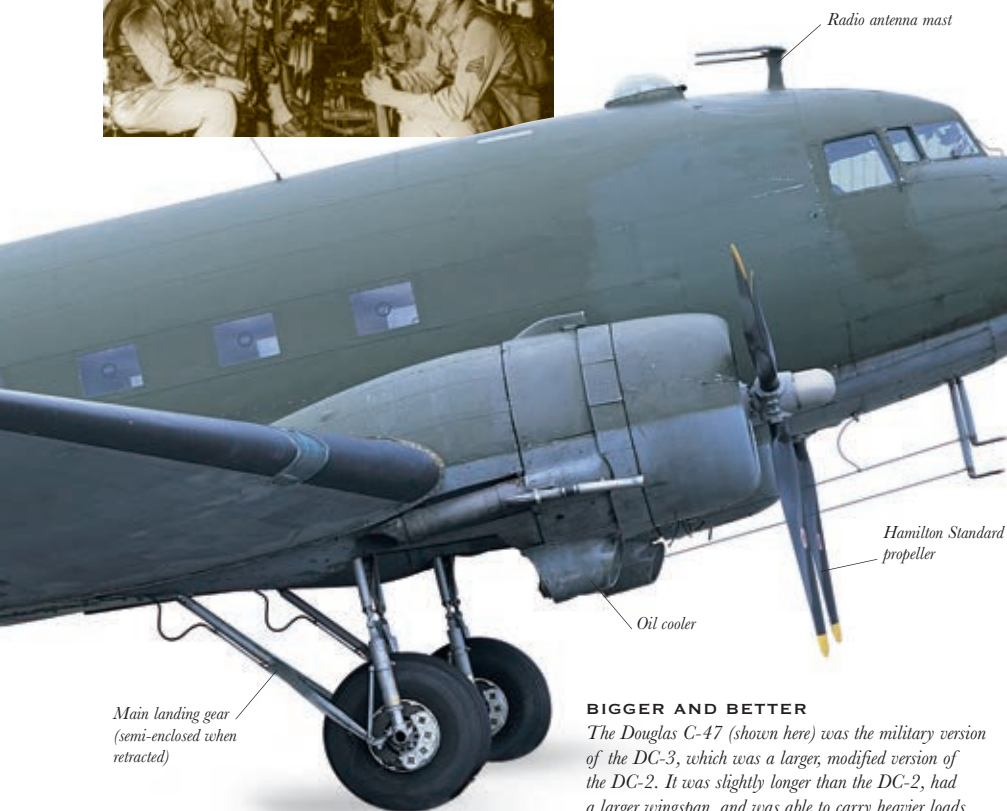
One of the features of the DC ("Douglas Commercials") line was its comfortable interior and smooth ride, enjoyed by pilots and passengers alike.

**HEAVY WORKLOAD**

A C-47 military transport carries US troops, along with a jeep and howitzer, into action during WWII. In addition to its roles as a heavy cargo and paratroop carrier, the C-47 was also used as a glider tug, a glider, a seaplane, and as the AC-47 "Spooky" gunship during the war in Vietnam.

**MASS PRODUCTION**

The DC-3/C-47 was perfectly adapted for mass production, shown here in a production line in an Oklahoma City plant. Altogether, over 10,000 were built, with at least another 2,500 produced under licence in the USSR and Japan.

**BIGGER AND BETTER**

The Douglas C-47 (shown here) was the military version of the DC-3, which was a larger, modified version of the DC-2. It was slightly longer than the DC-2, had a larger wingspan, and was able to carry heavier loads.

The air passengers of the late 1930s traveled in properly heated cabins, sound-proofed to reduce engine noise to a loud drone rather than a nerve-shattering roar. Sitting in padded seats that reduced vibration, they were served hot in-flight meals brought on board in giant thermos flasks. To pass the time they played games with the free packs of playing cards handed out in the cabin, or wrote cards or letters in flight that would then be mailed by the airline. DST sleeper services attained a more lavish style. Passengers changed into their nightwear in a luxurious lounge while their beds were made up. In the morning, stewardesses served breakfast in bed, and during the day the extra space afforded to the smaller than usual complement of passengers was exploited to provide linen-covered tables with fresh flowers in vases.

Into the stratosphere

But the problem of turbulence remained. Many flights were still a nightmare of air-sickness for those with a tender stomach. The only solution would be to fly above the clouds in the weather-free stratosphere. Here came a chance for Boeing to steal back the lead from Douglas. By the end of 1938 it had developed the four-engined B-307 Stratoliner, the first commercial airplane capable of operating at stratospheric height. A pressurized cabin protected the crew and passengers from the effects of high altitude, while turbo-superchargers allowed the engines to function efficiently in the thin upper air, their performance enhanced by new high-octane fuel.

The Stratoliner was not a commercial success, but it pointed the way forward for passenger aviation as the United States headed into World War II. No fundamental technical obstacle stood in the way of land planes developing nonstop transcontinental and transoceanic services, as the Focke-Wulf Condor had shown with its celebrated Berlin–New York flight in 1938. Once peace returned, propliners cruising the clear blue heights of the stratosphere would whisk globetrotters from city to city across the world.

**STRATOLINER**

Entering airline service in 1940, the Stratoliner – shown here on a publicity flight – gave passengers a smoother, faster ride than they had ever known before.